Chapter Four

Making Friends, 1921

The events of 1920 had shown that Curzon had been wrong in the policies he had tried to pursue in Persia. The 1919 agreement had been categorically rejected by the Persian people, and the Enzeli debacle had exposed the impotence of Britain's military for all to see. What is more, given the state of its economy, Britain no longer had the physical resources to support the forward policy which the foreign secretary favoured. Unfortunately for Curzon, Britain's position as unrivalled authority in South Asia was not to be. A change was now needed in Britain's foreign policy. But how far did the foreign secretary recognise this? And what was the change to be?

1920 had been a rude awakening for those in London who had been overly optimistic about the empire's capabilities in the post-war period. By 1921 it appeared that realism needed to be the order of the day – the guiding principle which the Indian government had been following itself since 1918.However, while Delhi was confident that Britain could still play a central role in South Asia even from a position of retrenchment, the Home government was not so convinced. Prestige was always a key factor in the international standing of the empire, but by 1921, without any economic or military clout, prestige appeared to be of even greater importance to many in London. How the empire was to pull back from its current position without appearing weak was a particular worry to the Home government, and one which would bring it into conflict with the Indian government yet again.

The changes which 1921 wrought on British foreign policy have been noted by other authors, albeit for quite different reasons. The Anglo-Soviet Trade Agreement was signed by Britain and Russia in 1921, and for some, this event has been seen as a watershed moment in the relationship between